

From Infrastructure to Cybersecurity

A practical roadmap for senior IT professionals

with 14+ years of experience

14+ Years

infrastructure expertise

3 Role Paths

mapped to your skills

30-Day Plan

actionable start today

India Focus

GCCs - MSSPs - IT firms

You have spent over a decade building, managing, and troubleshooting complex IT infrastructure. That expertise is not a liability in cybersecurity - it is your strongest competitive differentiator. This guide maps the fastest, most practical path to a well-paying cybersecurity role in India, without starting over.

CONTENTS

01 Why your infrastructure background is a superpower

02 Three target roles that match your profile

03 Certifications that open doors

04 30-day action plan

05 The Indian job market - where to look

06 Resume and LinkedIn keywords

07 The internal pivot strategy

08 Resources, labs and learning links

01 Why your infrastructure background is a superpower

Most cybersecurity professionals come from software or IT support backgrounds - and carry a critical blind spot: they have never actually built or run the infrastructure they are supposed to protect. You have. Your 14+ years gives you capabilities that cannot be acquired in a classroom.

Network fluency

You read firewall rules, understand routing protocols, and can spot suspicious traffic patterns that others dismiss. Attackers exploit network misconfigurations - you already know where they are.

Systems depth

You know how attackers move laterally across servers because you built those very systems. OS hardening, service accounts, patch cycles - this is your daily vocabulary.

Cloud hands-on experience

Hands-on AWS/Azure/GCP administration is now a hard prerequisite for senior security roles. Junior security analysts typically lack it. You already have it.

Business and operational context

You understand how IT operations actually run, making you far more effective in incident response and risk prioritisation. You know the difference between theory and production.

Vendor and tool familiarity

Years of enterprise hardware and software experience means faster ramp-up on security tooling - whether a SIEM, an EDR platform, or a cloud security posture management tool.

NOTE You are not changing careers. You are adding a specialisation on top of expertise that most security professionals spend years trying to acquire.

02 Three target roles that match your profile

Rather than applying broadly, focus your energy on the three role families below - each one rewards deep infrastructure knowledge and offers a direct bridge from your current title.

Security Engineer		Infrastructure and Network
The closest match to your background. You will manage firewalls, IDS/IPS, EDR, SIEM platforms, and secure network architecture. Companies actively seek people who can both design and defend infrastructure - not just read dashboards.		Key responsibilities: - Firewall and IDS/IPS management - Secure network architecture design - Vulnerability assessment and remediation - Cloud security controls (AWS / Azure) - Identity and access management (IAM)
Typical salary range: Rs.14L to Rs.30L depending on certifications and city		

SOC Analyst

Tier 2 / Tier 3 (not entry level)

With your infra background you enter at Tier 2 or Tier 3 - where knowing what normal network behaviour looks like is critical. This role is also a proven stepping stone to Security Architect or CISO tracks within 3 to 5 years.

Key responsibilities:

- SIEM alert triage (Splunk / Microsoft Sentinel)
- Threat hunting and log correlation
- Incident response and containment
- Forensic evidence preservation
- Reporting to security leadership

Typical salary range: Rs.10L to Rs.22L - rises sharply with CISSP or BTL1

Cloud Security Engineer

/ Architect

Cloud migrations are the single biggest security risk most Indian enterprises face today. A professional who understands both cloud infrastructure and security controls is scarce and commands a premium - especially in GCCs and BFSI sector clients.

Key responsibilities:

- Cloud IAM policy design and auditing
- Infrastructure-as-code (IaC) security
- Misconfiguration detection (CSPM tools)
- DevSecOps pipeline integration
- Compliance: ISO 27001, SOC 2, CIS Benchmarks

Typical salary range: Rs.18L to Rs.40L+ for architect-level roles

03 Certifications that open doors

Certifications validate your knowledge and get your CV past automated applicant-tracking systems. Pursue them in the order below - starting with the fastest wins, then building toward the senior credentials that maximise salary.

01 CompTIA Security+ <i>Core security fundamentals</i> The HR-screening baseline. Most enterprise job descriptions in India list this as a minimum requirement. Look for discounted vouchers from authorised partners such as Global IT Success.	Cost (INR) Rs.18,000 to Rs.22,000 Study time 60 days
02 Microsoft SC-200 or AZ-500 <i>Microsoft Security Ops / Azure Cloud</i> Very high demand among Indian MNCs running Microsoft/Azure environments. SC-200 covers Microsoft Sentinel and Defender; AZ-500 covers Azure security architecture. Microsoft's Indian localised pricing makes this outstanding value.	Cost (INR) Approx. Rs.4,800 + tax Study time 45 days
03 Blue Team Level 1 (BTL1) <i>Practical SOC operations</i> A respected hands-on certification proving real incident investigation skill - not just multiple-choice theory. MSSPs and GCC recruiters value this because it shows you can handle a live security event from day one.	Cost (INR) Rs.24,000 to Rs.40,000 Study time 90 days
04 CISSP <i>Security architecture and management</i> The gold standard for senior roles. With 14+ years of IT experience you already meet the 5-year work experience requirement. CISSP positions you for Security Architect and Head of Security roles - a significant salary step-change.	Cost (INR) Rs.65,000+ Study time 6 to 12 months
05 OSCP or CEH (optional) <i>Offensive / penetration testing</i> Pursue only if you want to specialise in red teaming or penetration testing. CEH is widely recognised in Indian corporate circles; OSCP is the global gold standard for practical offensive skills. Not required for defensive security roles.	Cost (INR) Varies Study time 3 to 6 months

TIP Start Security+ and SC-200 simultaneously - they share overlapping content and can both be completed within 90 days. Use these two to begin applying while you continue studying for BTL1.

04 30-day action plan

The goal of the next 30 days is not to learn everything - it is to build a visible, credible security profile you can point to in interviews. Each week has a specific, achievable focus.

Week 1	Foundation and environment setup
☐	Register on TryHackMe and begin the SOC Level 1 learning path
☐	Set up a free Microsoft Azure account and explore Microsoft Sentinel
☐	Install Splunk Free on a local VM - ingest sample logs and run basic queries
☐	Review your own infrastructure documentation with an attacker's mindset
☐	Download and read the NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0 (free)
Week 2	Enterprise security stack - tool familiarity
☐	Complete TryHackMe SOC Level 1 modules on SIEM fundamentals and Splunk
☐	Explore Microsoft Defender for Endpoint via the M365 Defender trial
☐	Practice basic Splunk SPL queries: search, filter, create alerts
☐	Register for Splunk Fundamentals 1 - free on Splunk's e-learning portal
☐	Review CrowdStrike Falcon concepts via their free online training
Week 3	Hands-on labs and incident response
☐	Create an account on Blue Team Labs Online (BTLO) - free tier available
☐	Complete 3 to 5 BTLO challenges in Log Analysis and Phishing Analysis
☐	Sign up for LetsDefend.io and work through the SOC Analyst simulation
☐	Practice a basic incident response tabletop using a public scenario
☐	Document lab findings - this becomes portfolio evidence for interviews
Week 4	Resume, LinkedIn and first applications
☐	Rewrite your resume using the security keyword list in Section 06
☐	Update LinkedIn headline to include security skills alongside infrastructure
☐	Begin Security+ study using Professor Messer's free video course
☐	Identify 5 target companies from the GCC, MSSP, and IT Services categories
☐	Apply for 2 to 3 roles to start calibrating the market

05 The Indian job market - where to look

With 14+ years of experience you are a senior or lead-level professional. Do not apply for entry-level SOC roles. Focus on these three employer categories, which actively seek infrastructure veterans and pay accordingly.

GCCs

Global Capability Centers

Multinationals including Walmart, Target, JP Morgan, Wells Fargo, Goldman Sachs and Cisco operate large technology hubs in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Chennai. They pay premium salaries for senior professionals who can secure enterprise infrastructure and bridge the gap between business risk and technical implementation.

Bengaluru - Hyderabad - Pune - Chennai

MSSPs

Managed Security Service Providers

Large MSSPs such as TCS Security, Infosys Cybersecurity, IBM Security, Secureworks and Verizon Business run outsourced Security Operations Centers for global clients. They hire senior infrastructure professionals as the technical backbone of their SOC and threat-hunting teams.

TCS - Infosys - IBM - Wipro - SecureWorks

Consulting

IT Services and Big Four Consulting

Tech Mahindra, HCL, Cognizant, EY, PwC and Deloitte routinely need senior infrastructure professionals to lead secure cloud migrations for clients across BFSI, healthcare and manufacturing. These roles often combine client-facing consulting with hands-on security work.

BFSI - Healthcare - Manufacturing - Retail

06 Resume and LinkedIn - keywords that get you hired

Applicant Tracking Systems scan resumes for specific terms before a human reads them. Reframe your existing experience in security language - you are describing what you already do in the vocabulary hiring managers search for.

Infrastructure security

- Network segmentation
- Firewall rule management
- IDS/IPS
- VPN architecture
- Zero Trust (ZTNA)
- DMZ design
- Network access control (NAC)

Security operations

Identity and access management

- Active Directory hardening
- Privileged access management (PAM)
- RBAC
- MFA
- Single sign-on (SSO)
- Identity governance

Cloud and compliance

- SIEM (Splunk / Sentinel)
- Log analysis and correlation
- Threat hunting
- Incident response
- Vulnerability management
- EDR (CrowdStrike / Defender)

- CSPM
- IAM policy hardening
- AWS Security Hub
- Azure Defender
- CIS Benchmarks
- ISO 27001
- SOC 2
- Data loss prevention (DLP)

07 The internal pivot strategy - do this first

Before you send a single external application, consider the fastest and lowest-risk path available: transitioning within your current organisation. This is consistently overlooked and consistently effective.

- YES No employment gap** - You transition directly without any period of unemployment.
- YES Immediate credibility** - 14 years of institutional knowledge cannot be hired externally.
- YES Salary protection** - Internal moves typically preserve or increase your compensation.
- YES No probation period** - You skip the standard 3 to 6 month probation for external hires.
- YES Portfolio evidence** - One year of internal security experience dramatically strengthens your CV.

Conversation template - how to approach your manager:

"I have spent 14 years building deep knowledge of our network architecture, server infrastructure and cloud environment. I have recently completed cybersecurity training in [course name] and I am actively pursuing [certification]. I believe I can add significant value as an infrastructure security liaison - bridging the security team and the infrastructure team, and hardening systems that I know inside and out. Could we explore a formal or informal collaboration to get started?"

08 Resources, labs and learning links

Hands-on learning platforms		
-	TryHackMe - SOC Level 1	tryhackme.com/path/outline/soclevel1
>		
-	TryHackMe - SOC Level 2	tryhackme.com/path/outline/soclevel2
>		
-	TryHackMe - Security Engineer Training	tryhackme.com/path/outline/security-engineer-training
>		
-	TryHackMe - DevSecOps Path	tryhackme.com/path/outline/devsecops
>		
-	TryHackMe - Red Teaming Path	tryhackme.com/path/outline/redteaming
>		
-	Blue Team Labs Online (BTLO)	blueteamlabs.online
>		
-	LetsDefend - SOC Analyst Simulation	letsdefend.io
>		

Certifications - official links

- **CompTIA Security+** comptia.org/certifications/security
>
- **ISC2 CISSP** isc2.org/certifications/cissp
>
- **Microsoft SC-200 Study Guide** learn.microsoft.com/certifications/exams/sc-200
>
- **Zero Point Security - CRT0 Red Team Operator** zeropointsecurity.co.uk/courses
>

Free study and compliance resources

- **Prabh Nair - Compliance and GRC for India** prabhnair.in
>
- **Prabh Nair YouTube Channel** youtube.com/@PrabhNair1
>
- **NIST Cybersecurity Framework 2.0** nist.gov/cyberframework
>
- **SANS Reading Room - free research papers** sans.org/white-papers
>
- **Splunk Fundamentals 1 (free)** splunk.com/en_us/training.html
>

You are not starting over. You are levelling up.

Every firewall you have configured, every network you have designed, every incident you have resolved - that is your security experience. It just did not have the right job title on it yet. The industry needs people who understand how systems actually work. That is you. Now it is simply a matter of connecting the credentials to the expertise.